

# PROVE IT!

## *A Cooperative Phrase-Identification Game*

English 2810a • Winter 2026

### **Roles (rotate every round)**

1. THE SPEAKER — Looks at the sentence and says, in plain English, what the underlined phrase is doing. No terminology. Just: “I think that part tells you where it happened” or “That’s what she found.” The Speaker’s judgment is the hypothesis that drives the round.
2. THE TESTER — Draws 3 Test Cards at random from the face-down pile. Picks which test(s) would best prove the Speaker’s intuition. Announces the test but doesn’t run it yet.
3. THE RUNNER — Actually performs the test: writes out the transformed sentence, checks whether it’s grammatical. Can consult the Speaker on grammaticality judgments (“Does ‘She found it easily’ sound right to you?”).
4. THE BUILDER — If the test confirms the hypothesis, lays down the Claim Cards (phrase type + function) and sketches the relevant tree fragment on scrap paper, showing where the phrase sits (sister to what?).

### **Scoring**

Each completed round = 1 point. Self-correction (group catches own error) = 2 points. Class goal: every group completes at least 5 rounds correctly.

### **Card Colours**

GREEN cards = Tests (what diagnostic to run)

PURPLE cards = Sentences (what to analyse)

TAN cards = Answers (flip after your group commits)

BLUE cards = Phrase Type claims (NP, VP, AdjP, AdvP, PP)

PINK cards = Function claims (Subject, Object, Modifier, etc.)

# TEST CARDS — Print on GREEN card stock

Print 4 copies of each test (24 cards total). Cut along borders.

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PRONOMINALIZATION</b><br>Replace the phrase with a pronoun (he, she, it, they, them, there). If the sentence is still grammatical → it's an NP.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>The pig from Mars left.</i> → <i>It left.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the pig from Mars] is an NP.</i>               | <b>COORDINATION</b><br>Coordinate the phrase with another phrase of the same type using and or or. If it works → confirms the phrase type.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>[very happy] and [extremely tired] both work as AdjPs.</i> ✓                                                                              |
| <b>MOVEMENT</b><br>Move the phrase to the front of the sentence. If the sentence is still grammatical (even if awkward) → it's a constituent.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>She ate in the dark.</i> → <i>In the dark, she ate.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [in the dark] is a phrase.</i>             | <b>OMISSION</b><br>Leave the phrase out. If the sentence is still grammatical → adverbial or modifier (optional). If ungrammatical → object or complement (obligatory).<br><b>Example:</b> <i>He slept during the meeting.</i> → <i>He slept.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [during the meeting] is an adverbial.</i> |
| <b>PASSIVIZATION</b><br>Try to make the phrase the subject of a passive sentence. If it works → it's an object (direct, indirect, or prepositional).<br><b>Example:</b> <i>She read the letter.</i> → <i>The letter was read.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the letter] is a direct object.</i> | <b>AGREEMENT</b><br>Change the number of the phrase (sg ↔ pl). If the verb form changes too → it's the subject.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>The moon has risen.</i> → <i>The moons have risen.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the moon] is the subject.</i>                                                                 |
| <b>PRONOMINALIZATION</b><br>Replace the phrase with a pronoun (he, she, it, they, them, there). If the sentence is still grammatical → it's an NP.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>The pig from Mars left.</i> → <i>It left.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the pig from Mars] is an NP.</i>               | <b>COORDINATION</b><br>Coordinate the phrase with another phrase of the same type using and or or. If it works → confirms the phrase type.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>[very happy] and [extremely tired] both work as AdjPs.</i> ✓                                                                              |
| <b>MOVEMENT</b><br>Move the phrase to the front of the sentence. If the sentence is still grammatical (even if awkward) → it's a constituent.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>She ate in the dark.</i> → <i>In the dark, she ate.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [in the dark] is a phrase.</i>             | <b>OMISSION</b><br>Leave the phrase out. If the sentence is still grammatical → adverbial or modifier (optional). If ungrammatical → object or complement (obligatory).<br><b>Example:</b> <i>He slept during the meeting.</i> → <i>He slept.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [during the meeting] is an adverbial.</i> |
| <b>PASSIVIZATION</b><br>Try to make the phrase the subject of a passive sentence. If it works → it's an object (direct, indirect, or prepositional).<br><b>Example:</b> <i>She read the letter.</i> → <i>The letter was read.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the letter] is a direct object.</i> | <b>AGREEMENT</b><br>Change the number of the phrase (sg ↔ pl). If the verb form changes too → it's the subject.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>The moon has risen.</i> → <i>The moons have risen.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the moon] is the subject.</i>                                                                 |
| <b>PRONOMINALIZATION</b><br>Replace the phrase with a pronoun (he, she, it, they, them, there). If the sentence is still grammatical → it's an NP.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>The pig from Mars left.</i> → <i>It left.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the pig from Mars] is an NP.</i>               | <b>COORDINATION</b><br>Coordinate the phrase with another phrase of the same type using and or or. If it works → confirms the phrase type.<br><b>Example:</b> <i>[very happy] and [extremely tired] both work as AdjPs.</i> ✓                                                                              |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p style="text-align: center;"><b>MOVEMENT</b></p> <p>Move the phrase to the front of the sentence. If the sentence is still grammatical (even if awkward) → it's a constituent.</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>She ate in the dark.</i> → <i>In the dark, she ate.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [in the dark] is a phrase.</i></p>             | <p style="text-align: center;"><b>OMISSION</b></p> <p>Leave the phrase out. If the sentence is still grammatical → adverbial or modifier (optional). If ungrammatical → object or complement (obligatory).</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>He slept during the meeting.</i> → <i>He slept.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [during the meeting] is an adverbial.</i></p> |
| <p style="text-align: center;"><b>PASSIVIZATION</b></p> <p>Try to make the phrase the subject of a passive sentence. If it works → it's an object (direct, indirect, or prepositional).</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>She read the letter.</i> → <i>The letter was read.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [the letter] is a direct object.</i></p> | <p style="text-align: center;"><b>AGREEMENT</b></p> <p>Change the number of the phrase (sg ↔ pl). If the verb form changes too → it's the subject.</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>The moon has risen.</i> → <i>The moons have risen.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [the moon] is the subject.</i></p>                                                                 |
| <p style="text-align: center;"><b>PRONOMINALIZATION</b></p> <p>Replace the phrase with a pronoun (he, she, it, they, them, there). If the sentence is still grammatical → it's an NP.</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>The pig from Mars left.</i> → <i>It left.</i> ✓ <i>Therefore [the pig from Mars] is an NP.</i></p>                    | <p style="text-align: center;"><b>COORDINATION</b></p> <p>Coordinate the phrase with another phrase of the same type using and or or. If it works → confirms the phrase type.</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>[very happy] and [extremely tired] both work as AdjPs.</i> ✓</p>                                                                                   |
| <p style="text-align: center;"><b>MOVEMENT</b></p> <p>Move the phrase to the front of the sentence. If the sentence is still grammatical (even if awkward) → it's a constituent.</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>She ate in the dark.</i> → <i>In the dark, she ate.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [in the dark] is a phrase.</i></p>             | <p style="text-align: center;"><b>OMISSION</b></p> <p>Leave the phrase out. If the sentence is still grammatical → adverbial or modifier (optional). If ungrammatical → object or complement (obligatory).</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>He slept during the meeting.</i> → <i>He slept.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [during the meeting] is an adverbial.</i></p> |
| <p style="text-align: center;"><b>PASSIVIZATION</b></p> <p>Try to make the phrase the subject of a passive sentence. If it works → it's an object (direct, indirect, or prepositional).</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>She read the letter.</i> → <i>The letter was read.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [the letter] is a direct object.</i></p> | <p style="text-align: center;"><b>AGREEMENT</b></p> <p>Change the number of the phrase (sg ↔ pl). If the verb form changes too → it's the subject.</p> <p><b>Example:</b> <i>The moon has risen.</i> → <i>The moons have risen.</i> ✓<br/> <i>Therefore [the moon] is the subject.</i></p>                                                                 |

# SENTENCE CARDS — Print on PURPLE card stock

★ = straightforward   ★★ = moderate   ★★★ = complex. Cut along borders.

|                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ★☆☆<br>The students found the answer.<br>Identify: <u>the answer</u>                                                        | ★☆☆<br>She left quickly.<br>Identify: <u>quickly</u>                                                                             |
| ★☆☆<br>The old cat slept on the mat.<br>Identify: <u>on the mat</u>                                                         | ★☆☆<br>They seemed very happy.<br>Identify: <u>very happy</u>                                                                    |
| ★☆☆<br>He gave her the book.<br>Identify: <u>her</u>                                                                        | ★☆☆<br>The rabbit planted carrots.<br>Identify: <u>The rabbit</u>                                                                |
| ★★☆<br>The pig from Mars left relatively early.<br>Identify: <u>from Mars</u>                                               | ★★☆<br>Fortunately, she found it easily.<br>Identify: <u>Fortunately</u>                                                         |
| ★★☆<br>He referred to that article.<br>Identify: <u>to that article</u>                                                     | ★★☆<br>The students considered the problem difficult.<br>Identify: <u>difficult</u>                                              |
| ★★☆<br>A very curious red book was found.<br>Identify: <u>very curious</u>                                                  | ★★☆<br>Wisely, they left before dark.<br>Identify: <u>Wisely</u>                                                                 |
| ★★★<br>A teacher of physics from England won the prize.<br>Identify: <u>of physics</u>                                      | ★★★<br>A teacher of physics from England won the prize.<br>Identify: <u>from England</u>                                         |
| ★★★<br>The attack on the conclusions of that report shocked everyone.<br>Identify: <u>on the conclusions of that report</u> | ★★★<br>She spotted the man with the binoculars.<br>Identify: <u>with the binoculars</u>                                          |
| ★★★<br>He hides behind the pile of books on his desk.<br>Identify: <u>on his desk</u>                                       | ★★★<br>The blatantly illegal plan worried the extremely cautious professor of linguistics.<br>Identify: <u>blatantly illegal</u> |

# ANSWER CARDS — Print on TAN/CREAM card stock

Match to sentence cards by star rating and sentence text. Keep face-down; flip only after the group commits.

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p>☆☆☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>The students found the answer.</i></p> <p><b>the answer = NP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Direct Object</p> <p><i>Pronominalize: found it. Passivize: The answer was found.</i></p>                                                                                                           | <p>☆☆☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>She left quickly.</i></p> <p><b>quickly = AdvP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> VP-Adverbial</p> <p><i>Omit: She left. Still grammatical → optional → adverbial.</i></p>                                                                                                                                     |
| <p>☆☆☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>The old cat slept on the mat.</i></p> <p><b>on the mat = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> VP-Adverbial</p> <p><i>Omit: The old cat slept. Still grammatical → adverbial. Cannot passivize: *The mat was slept on.</i></p>                                                                      | <p>☆☆☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>They seemed very happy.</i></p> <p><b>very happy = AdjP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Subject Predicate</p> <p><i>Cannot omit: *They seemed. Cannot passivize. Describes the subject they.</i></p>                                                                                                        |
| <p>☆☆☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>He gave her the book.</i></p> <p><b>her = NP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Indirect Object</p> <p><i>Passivize: She was given the book. Can rephrase with to: gave the book to her.</i></p>                                                                                                    | <p>☆☆☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>The rabbit planted carrots.</i></p> <p><b>The rabbit = NP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Subject</p> <p><i>Agreement: The rabbits planted carrots (verb changes). Tag: ...didn't it?</i></p>                                                                                                               |
| <p>★★☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>The pig from Mars left relatively early.</i></p> <p><b>from Mars = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Modifier (inside NP)</p> <p><i>Modifies pig, not the VP. Pronominalize the whole NP: It left. The PP is part of the NP, not a separate adverbial.</i></p>                                  | <p>★★☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>Fortunately, she found it easily.</i></p> <p><b>Fortunately = AdvP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> S-Adverbial</p> <p><i>Omit: She found it easily. Still grammatical. Expresses speaker's attitude about the whole sentence, not the VP.</i></p>                                                           |
| <p>★★☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>He referred to that article.</i></p> <p><b>to that article = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Prepositional Object</p> <p><i>Cannot omit: *He referred. Passivize: That article was referred to. → object, not adverbial.</i></p>                                                              | <p>★★☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>The students considered the problem difficult.</i></p> <p><b>difficult = AdjP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Object Predicate</p> <p><i>Cannot omit: *The students considered the problem. Describes the object the problem.</i></p>                                                                       |
| <p>★★☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>A very curious red book was found.</i></p> <p><b>very curious = AdjP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Modifier (inside NP)</p> <p><i>Modifies the head noun book. Coordinate: A very curious and extremely old book. Sister to N'.</i></p>                                                        | <p>★★☆ ANSWER</p> <p><i>Wisely, they left before dark.</i></p> <p><b>Wisely = AdvP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> S-Adverbial</p> <p><i>Two readings: (1) they were wise to leave (S-adv) or (2) they left in a wise manner (VP-adv). Sentence-initial + comma → S-adverbial.</i></p>                                              |
| <p>★★★ ANSWER</p> <p><i>A teacher of physics from England won the prize.</i></p> <p><b>of physics = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Complement (inside NP)</p> <p><i>Cannot reverse: *a teacher from England of physics. One-substitution: a teacher of physics from England → one from England. Sister to N.</i></p> | <p>★★★ ANSWER</p> <p><i>A teacher of physics from England won the prize.</i></p> <p><b>from England = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Modifier (inside NP)</p> <p><i>Can reverse only after complement: a teacher of physics from England. One-substitution: one from England replaces teacher of physics. Sister to N'.</i></p> |
| <p>★★★ ANSWER</p> <p><i>The attack on the conclusions of that report shocked everyone.</i></p> <p><b>on the conclusions of that report = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Complement (inside NP)</p> <p><i>Attack is verb-like (cf. attacked the conclusions). The PP = what was</i></p>                               | <p>★★★ ANSWER</p> <p><i>She spotted the man with the binoculars.</i></p> <p><b>with the binoculars = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> AMBIGUOUS</p> <p><i>Two trees: (1) PP modifies man (sister to N') → the man who has</i></p>                                                                                                 |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><i>attacked. Sister to N.</i></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <p><i>binoculars; (2) PP is VP-adverbial (sister to V') → she used binoculars to spot him.</i></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <p>★★★ ANSWER</p> <p><i>He hides behind the pile of books on his desk.</i></p> <p><b>on his desk = PP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Modifier (inside NP, modifying pile)</p> <p><i>Modifies pile, not hides. If VP-adverbial, it would mean he hides ON his desk. Sister to N'.</i></p> | <p>★★★ ANSWER</p> <p><i>The blatantly illegal plan worried the extremely cautious professor of linguistics.</i></p> <p><b>blatantly illegal = AdjP</b></p> <p><b>Function:</b> Modifier (inside NP)</p> <p><i>Modifies plan. blatantly is AdvP modifier to Adj head illegal. The AdjP is sister to N'.</i></p> |

PHRASE TYPE CARDS — Print on BLUE card stock

3 copies of each type (15 cards). Cut along borders.

|                                   |                                   |                                   |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>NP</b>   | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>VP</b>   | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>AdjP</b> |
| <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>AdvP</b> | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>PP</b>   | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>NP</b>   |
| <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>VP</b>   | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>AdjP</b> | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>AdvP</b> |
| <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>PP</b>   | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>NP</b>   | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>VP</b>   |
| <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>AdjP</b> | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>AdvP</b> | <i>Phrase Type</i><br><b>PP</b>   |

FUNCTION CARDS — Print on PINK card stock

2 copies of each function (22 cards). Cut along borders.

|                                             |                                             |                                            |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <i>Function</i><br><b>Subject</b>           | <i>Function</i><br><b>Direct Object</b>     | <i>Function</i><br><b>Indirect Object</b>  |
| <i>Function</i><br><b>Prep. Object</b>      | <i>Function</i><br><b>Subject Predicate</b> | <i>Function</i><br><b>Object Predicate</b> |
| <i>Function</i><br><b>VP-Adverbial</b>      | <i>Function</i><br><b>S-Adverbial</b>       | <i>Function</i><br><b>Modifier</b>         |
| <i>Function</i><br><b>Complement</b>        | <i>Function</i><br><b>Head</b>              | <i>Function</i><br><b>Subject</b>          |
| <i>Function</i><br><b>Direct Object</b>     | <i>Function</i><br><b>Indirect Object</b>   | <i>Function</i><br><b>Prep. Object</b>     |
| <i>Function</i><br><b>Subject Predicate</b> | <i>Function</i><br><b>Object Predicate</b>  | <i>Function</i><br><b>VP-Adverbial</b>     |
| <i>Function</i><br><b>S-Adverbial</b>       | <i>Function</i><br><b>Modifier</b>          | <i>Function</i><br><b>Complement</b>       |
| <i>Function</i><br><b>Head</b>              |                                             |                                            |